the past two decades], incidents of communal riots have been negligible [in the past 25 years]. Then why is the DAA's scope being increased periodically," asks the source cognisant of the case. The government, in its last submission to the court last year, had said it is bringing in legislation that will render the petition infructuous.

Talking about the Muslim woman's case, Sharik Laliwala, a PhD student of political science at the University of California, Berkeley, says, "It is an unspoken rule that Muslims will not be allotted houses in government schemes outside the ghettos". Laliwala, who grew up in Ahmedabad and studies religious politics in India, is of the opinion that the purpose of the Act is as much to restrict property transactions as to actively polarise minds at large. A natural consequence is that property prices in Muslim enclaves are 30 per cent higher as space is very scarce, he adds. Moving a private member's bill in the state assembly in March 2023, Khadia-Jamalpur MLA Imran Khedawala had submitted that the Act should be withdrawn. "This (DAA) has become an instrument for wide-spread corruption and malpractices in the administration...," he had submitted.

Top sources in the state government, though, rationalise the Act saying the circumstances for it predate the BJP government. It reflects the fabric of Gujarat society, and is not something imposed by the BJP, says one of them, adding that communities like the Patidars and Jains also prefer to live in their own enclaves. Defending the 2019 amendments when they were proposed in the assembly, then minister Bhupendrasinh Chudasama had said it was a reaction to complaints of "loopholes in the Act being misused". He claimed the collector's restricted role had resulted in anti-social elements trading in land and properties by intimidating and luring sellers. The amendment sought to stop "clustering" and to "maintain the demographic equilibrium" of the locality, he said. The law clearly has uses for euphemisms. ■



NO MORE LINING UP
The GNSS-based tolling system will mean such scenes at tolling plazas would be a thing of the past

HINDUSTAN TIMES

NATIONAL HIGHWAYS

THE TOLL OF TOLLS

By Avishek G. Dastidar

Five years after overhauling India's highway toll collection with FASTags, the Modi government is gearing up for its next ambitious move: a Global Navigation Satellite System (GNSS)-based tolling system. It aims to eliminate manned toll booths altogether, promising a seamless and automated tolling experience for commuters and long-haul drivers. The GNSS-based technology will track vehicles via satellites and levy charges based on the exact distance travelled. This ensures users pay only for the portion of the highway they use. The elimination of manned booths will allow vehicles to enter and exit highways seamlessly and improve fuel efficiency.

The system will use a network of satellites that transmit signals to a GNSS receiver in the vehicle, thus calculating the vehicle's exact location, speed and direction by triangulating signals from multiple satellites. This way, the system can precisely determine how far motorists have travelled on a toll road and charge them accordingly. To use the new system, drivers must register their vehicles and link their bank accounts. Additionally, existing FASTags will need to be linked to the new GPS-based tolling system. To ensure communication between vehicles and satellites, telecom towers will be installed along highways.

The government told Parliament during the ongoing Budget session that a pilot study of the system has been done on the Bengaluru-Mysore section of NH-275